

Cherish Ardinger, PhD

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Education

2018 - 2023 Indianapolis, IN	PhD, Addiction Neuroscience Indiana University-Purdue University Indianapolis (IUPUI)
2018 – 2020 Indianapolis, IN	Master of Science, Psychology Indiana University-Purdue University Indianapolis (IUPUI)
2014 - 2016 Towson, MD	Master of Arts, Experimental Psychology Towson University
2010 - 2014 Towson, MD	Bachelor of Science, Psychology Towson University <i>Cum Laude, Psychology Departmental Honors</i> Minor in LGBT (Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender) Studies

Positions

Sep 2025 – Present Piscataway, NJ	Rutgers Presidential Postdoctoral Fellow Department of Cell Biology and Neuroscience <i>Mentor:</i> Rafiq Huda, PhD <u><i>Current Research Interests:</i></u> I am broadly interested in studying the neurobiological causes of and identifying treatments for addiction. My current research focuses on how astrocyte modulation of cell specific striatum circuits contribute to alcohol-related behaviors.
Jan 2024 – Sep '25 Piscataway, NJ	Postdoctoral Fellow, Rutgers University WM Keck Center for Collaborative Neuroscience Department of Cell Biology and Neuroscience <i>Mentor:</i> Rafiq Huda, PhD
2018 – 2023 Indianapolis, IN	Addiction Neuroscience Doctoral Student, Indiana University-Purdue University Indianapolis (IUPUI) <i>Mentors:</i> Drs. Christopher Lapish and Nicholas Grahame <u><i>Master's Thesis Title:</i></u> Determining the impact of repeated binge drinking on corticostriatal theta synchrony <u><i>Dissertation Title:</i></u> Leveraging whole brain imaging to identify brain regions involved in alcohol frontloading
2015 – 2018 Edgewood, MD <i>Aberdeen Proving Ground</i>	Oak Ridge Institute for Science and Education (ORISE) Fellow, U.S. Army Medical Research Institute of Chemical Defense (USAMRICD) <i>Mentor:</i> John H. McDonough, PhD <u><i>Description:</i></u> Dr. McDonough's research program primarily focuses on identifying novel treatments for nerve agent-induced seizures. My ORISE fellowship provided training in surgical procedures, EEG data analyses, and significantly developed my laboratory management, mentorship, and scientific communication skills.
2012 – 2016 Towson, MD	Master's and Undergraduate Honors Thesis Student, Towson University <i>Mentor:</i> Paul Pistell, PhD <u><i>Master's Thesis Title:</i></u> The use of 3-nitropropionic acid to create a model of aging in mice

Undergraduate Honors Thesis Title: Creation of a peripheral lesion model to examine age-associated learning and memory deficits in mice

2009 – 2011
Frederick, MD
Fort Detrick

NIH Summer Internship Program (SIP) Student Intern
Laboratory of Molecular Immunoregulation, The National Cancer Institute
Mentors: Drs. Katie Stagliano and Arthur Hurwitz
Project: Validation of a prostate-specific STAT3C expression construct

2012 – 2014
Towson, MD

Research Team Member
Gender Identity and Sexuality Lab, Towson University
Mentor: M. Paz Galupo, PhD

Grants and Training Support

- Sep 2025 – Present **Rutgers Presidential Postdoctoral Fellowship**
- Jan 2025 - Present **NIAAA F32: Astrocyte modulation of striatal neuronal activity and behavioral sensitivity to alcohol (AA032173-01)**
- 2024 – 2025 **NIDA T32: Rutgers Training in Addiction Research Program (DA055569)**, Dr. Christopher Pierce (Principal Investigator), Dr. Rafiq Huda (supervisor / mentor).
- 2022 – 2023 **NIAAA T32: Training Grant on Genetic Aspects of Alcoholism (AA007462)**, Dr. Cristine Czachowski (Principal Investigator), Drs. Nicholas Grahame and Christopher Lapish (supervisors / mentors).

Pre-Prints

1) **C. Ardinger**, A. Kalelkar, M. Madden, A. Gunda, A. Patel, G. Xanthos, M. Mahboob, A. Khawaja, N. Collie-Beard, M. Bocarsly, R. Huda (2026). Dorsal Striatal Circuit Mechanisms Contributing to Astrocyte Modulation of Alcohol-Related Behaviors. Available as a pre-print on *BioRxiv*. PMID: 42282508

Publications

<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/myncbi/cherish.ardinger.1/bibliography/public/>

- 1) **C. Ardinger**, M. D. Morningstar, C. C. Lapish, D. N. Linsenbardt. (2025). Repeated Alcohol Drinking in Mice is Associated with Bidirectional Alterations in Corticostriatal Coherence. *Neuropharmacology*. PMID: 40389153
- 2) **C. Ardinger**, Y. Chen, A. Kimbrough, N. J. Grahame, C. C. Lapish. (2024). Sex Differences in Neural Networks Recruited by Frontloaded Binge Alcohol Drinking. *Addiction Biology*. PMID: 39256902
- 3) N. M. Timme, **C. Ardinger**, S. D. C. Weir, R. Zelaya-Escobar, R. Kruger, C. C. Lapish (2023). Non-consummatory behavior signals predict aversion-resistance in head-fixed mice. *Neuropharmacology*. PMID: 37871677
- 4) **C. Ardinger**, C. C. Lapish, C. L. Czachowski, N. J. Grahame (2022). A Critical Review of Front-loading: A Maladaptive Drinking Pattern Driven by Alcohol's Rewarding Effects. *Alcoholism: Clinical and Experimental Research (ACER)*. PMID: 36239713
 - **Awarded the 2023 ACER Journal Award for Early Career Investigator Outstanding Paper**
 - **Chosen by ACER as an Article of Public Interest!** ([link](#))
- 5) **C. Ardinger**, G. Winkler, C. C. Lapish, N. J. Grahame (2021). Effect of ketamine on binge drinking patterns in crossed high alcohol-preferring (cHAP) mice. *Alcohol*. PMID: 34547429
- 6) **C. Ardinger**, N. J. Grahame, C. C. Lapish, D. N. Linsenbardt (2020). High Alcohol Preferring Mice Show Reaction to Loss of Ethanol Reward Following Repeated Binge Drinking. *Alcoholism: Clinical and Experimental Research (ACER)*. PMID: 32865852
 - **Chosen by ACER as an Article of Public Interest!** ([link](#))

- 7) H. S. McCarren, M. Eisen, D. Nguyen, P. Dubee, **C. Ardinger**, E. Dunn, K. Haines, A. Santoro, P. Bodner, C. Ondeck, C. Honnold, J. H. McDonough, P. Beske, P. McNutt. (2020). Characterization and treatment of spontaneous recurrent seizures following nerve agent-induced status epilepticus in mice. *Epilepsy Research*. PMID: 32182542
- 8) E. Dunn, L. Matson, K. Haines, K. Whitten, R. B. Lee-Stubbs, K. Berger, H. S. McCarren, **C. Ardinger**, C. Jackson-Piercy, S. M. Miller-Smith, J. H. McDonough. (2020). Evaluation of fosphenytoin, levetiracetam and propofol as treatments for nerve agent-induced seizures in pediatric and adult rats. *Neurotoxicology*. PMID: 32220603
- 9) C. Jackson*, **C. Ardinger***, J. H. McDonough, H. S. McCarren (2019) Validating a model of nerve agent-induced status-epilepticus by evaluating the anticonvulsant and neuroprotective effects of scopolamine, memantine, and phenobarbital. *Journal of Pharmacological and Toxicological Methods*. PMID: 30790623 *contributed equally
- 10) L. Matson, E. Dunn, K. Haines, S. Miller-Smith, R. Lee-Stubbs, K. Whitten, **C. Ardinger**, H. McCarren, J. H. McDonough. (2019). Evaluation of first line anticonvulsants to treat nerve agent-induced seizures and prevent neuropathology in adult and pediatric rats. *Toxicology*. PMID: 31362008
- 11) H. S. McCarren, J. Arbutus, **C. Ardinger**, E. Dunn, C. Jackson, J. H. McDonough (2018) Dexmedetomidine stops nerve agent-induced status epilepticus. *Epilepsy Research*. PMID: 29414381
- 12) K. Haines, L. Matson, E. Dunn, **C. Ardinger**, D. Bibi, J. H. McDonough, M. Bialer (2018) Comparative efficacy of valnoctamide and sec-butylpropylacetamide (SPD) in terminating nerve agent-induced seizures in pediatric rats. *Epilepsia*. PMID: 30615805
- 13) L. Matson, R. B. Lee-Stubbs, L. Cadieux, J. A. Koenig, **C. Ardinger**, J. Chandler, E. A. Johnson, H. M. Hoard-Fruchey, T.M. Shih, J. H. McDonough (2018) Assessment of mouse strain differences in baseline esterase activities and toxic response to sarin. *Toxicology*. PMID: 30172647

Honors and Awards

Aug 2026	Abstract "Dorsal striatal circuit mechanisms contributing to astrocyte modulation of alcohol-related behaviors" selected for talk at the <i>Cold Spring Harbor Glia in Health & Disease Meeting</i> , Cold Spring Harbor, NY.
Feb 2026	Abstract "Circuit mechanisms contributing to astrocyte modulation of alcohol-related behaviors" selected for talk at the <i>Alcohol and the Nervous System Gordon Research Conference</i> , Ventura, CA.
Apr 2024	Rutgers Brain Health Institute Trainee Travel Award
Apr 2023	Research Society on Alcohol (RSA) Student Merit Award
Mar 2023	ACER Journal Award for Early Career Investigator Outstanding Paper Awarded for publication: A Critical Review of Front-loading: A Maladaptive Drinking Pattern Driven by Alcohol's Rewarding Effects. PMID: 36239713.
Dec 2022	Paul J. McKinley Graduate Student Award for Outreach, Public Engagement, and Diversity Awarded to IUPUI Addiction Neuroscience graduate students who display a dedication to service in these areas.
Apr 2022	Research Society on Alcoholism (RSA) Student Merit Award
Apr 2022	Best Graduate Student Poster, Greater Indiana Society for Neuroscience
Oct 2019	School of Science Graduate Student Council Travel Grant (IUPUI)

May 2019	Research Society on Alcoholism (RSA) Student Merit Award
Dec 2012-Present	Psi Chi , International Honors Society in Psychology, member
May 2013	Undergraduate Student Travel Award (Towson University)
Jan 2013	Undergraduate Research Grant (Towson University)

Conference Sessions Organized

- 1) Dancing with the stars: Emerging roles for astrocytes in alcohol-related behaviors (Jun 2026); *Research Society on Alcohol* Conference Symposium, San Antonio, TX. Organizer: **C. Ardinger**, Co-Organizer: R. Huda.
- 2) Front-loading your way to an AUD: The relationship between drinking rate, intoxication, and motivation to experience the subjective effects of alcohol (Jun 2022). *Research Society on Alcohol* Conference round-table session. Orlando, FL. Organizer: **C. Ardinger**; Co-organizer: N. J. Grahame.
- 3) From biobanks to behavior: How shared bioresources and genetic pipelines drive ethical innovation in preclinical alcohol research (Jun 2026); *Research Society on Alcohol* Conference Symposium, San Antonio, TX. Organizer: J. Rinker, Co-Organizer: **C. Ardinger**.

Talks

- 1) Dorsal striatal circuit mechanisms contributing to astrocyte modulation of alcohol-related behaviors. (Aug 2026). Presented at the *Cold Spring Harbor Glia in Health & Disease Meeting*, Cold Spring Harbor, NY.
- 2) Alcohol dose-dependently inhibits striatal astrocyte calcium activity: Implications for behavior and an ongoing search for the mechanism (Jun 2026). Presented at the *Research Society on Alcohol Conference*, San Antonio, TX.
- 3) Circuit mechanisms contributing to astrocyte modulation of alcohol-related behaviors (Feb 2026). Presented at the *Alcohol and the Nervous System Gordon Research Conference*, Ventura, CA.
- 4) Astrocyte effects of alcohol in the dorsolateral striatum (Apr 2025). Presented at the *Rutgers Training in Addiction Program Symposium*, New Brunswick, NJ.
- 5) Dorsal striatum astrocytes modulate alcohol-related behaviors (Sep 2024). Presented at the *Rutgers Addiction Research Center Symposium*, New Brunswick, NJ.
- 6) Front-loading: Evidence that mice consume alcohol to experience its subjective rewarding effects (Jun 2022). Presented at the *Research Society on Alcoholism* Conference, Orlando, FL.
- 7) Alcohol binge drinking results in sex-specific effects on corticostriatal activity (May 2022). *Oak Ridge Institute for Science and Education (ORISE) seminar series at the United States Army Medical Research Institute of Chemical Defense (USAMRICD)*, Edgewood, MD.
- 8) High alcohol preferring mice may represent a rodent model of high intensity drinking (Mar 2021). Virtual presentation at the *IUPUI, Wake Forest, and Medical University of South Carolina Alcohol Research Center (ARC) Trainee Showcase*.

Conference Poster Presentations

- 1) **C. Ardinger**, A. Kalelkar, M. Madden, A. Gunda, A. Patel, G. Xanthos, M. Mahboob, A. Khawaja, M. Bocarsly, & R. Huda (Feb 2026). Alcohol dose-dependently inhibits striatal astrocyte calcium activity:

Implications for behavior and an ongoing search for the mechanism. Poster presented at the *Alcohol and the Nervous System Gordon Research Conference and Seminar*, Ventura, CA.

2) **C. Ardinger**, A. Kalelkar, M. Madden, A. Gunda, A. Patel, G. Xanthos, M. Mahboob, A. Khawaja, A. Vellore, N. Collie-Beard, M. Bocarsly, & R. Huda. (June 2025). Astrocyte Effects of Alcohol in the Dorsolateral Striatum. Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcohol Conference*, New Orleans, LA.

3) T. Nguyen, **C. Ardinger**, G. Winkler, & N. Grahame. Crossed High Alcohol Preferring x High Drinking in the Dark (cHAP x HDID) Mice: A Flexible, Valid Model for Alcohol Use Disorder. (June 2025). Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcohol Conference*, New Orleans, LA.

4) **C. Ardinger**, A. Kalelkar, M. Mahboob, A. Vellore, W. Evans, M. Bocarsly, R. Huda (February 2025). Astrocyte effects of alcohol in the dorsolateral striatum. Poster presented at the *Glial Biology: Functional Interactions Among Glia and Neurons Gordon Research Conference and Seminar*, Ventura, CA.

5) **C. Ardinger**, A. Kalelkar, M. Mahboob, W. Evans, M. Bocarsly, R. Huda (June 2024). Dorsal striatum astrocytes modulate alcohol-related behaviors. Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcohol Conference*, Minneapolis, MN.

6) **C. Ardinger**, Y. Chen, A. Kimbrough, N. J. Grahame, & C. C. Lapish (Feb 2024). Frontloading, Binge-drinking mice show sex differences in neural networks recruited by alcohol. Poster presented at the *Alcohol and the Nervous System Gordon Research Seminar and Conference*, Galveston, TX.

7) **C. Ardinger**, Y. Chen, A. Kimbrough, N. J. Grahame, & C. C. Lapish (Jun 2023). Leveraging whole brain imaging to identify brain regions involved in alcohol front-loading. Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcohol Conference*, Bellevue, WA.

8) **C. Ardinger**, C. C. Lapish, N. J. Grahame, & D. N. Linsenbardt (Apr, Jun & Oct 2022). Sex differences in corticostriatal activity following repeated binge drinking. Poster presented at the *Greater Indiana Society for Neuroscience Conference*, Indianapolis, IN, *Research Society on Alcoholism Conference*, Orlando, FL and at the *Alcohol and the Nervous System Gordon Research Seminar and Conference*, Oxnard, CA.

- **Awarded best graduate student poster, Greater Indiana Society for Neuroscience**

9) C. Rangel-Barajas, **C. Ardinger**, N. J. Grahame, S. L. Boehm, M. L. Logrip (Jun 2022). Disrupted synaptic transmission in the dorsomedial striatum after chronic alcohol consumption in the selectively bred crossed high alcohol-preferring mice. Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcoholism Conference*, Orlando, FL.

10) G. A. Winkler, **C. Ardinger**, C. C. Lapish, J. C. Crabbe, & N. J. Grahame (Jun 2022). Free choice drinking increases subsequent drinking in the dark in crossed high alcohol-preferring x high drinking in the dark (cHAPxHDID) mice. Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcoholism Conference*, Orlando, FL.

11) N. M. Timme, **C. Ardinger**, R. Zelaya-Escobar, S. D. C. Weir, J. A. Stewart, and C. C. Lapish (Jun 2022). Assessing aversion-resistant alcohol consumption in head-fixed mice. Poster presented at the *Research Society on Alcoholism Conference*, Orlando, FL.

12) S. D. Weir, **C. Ardinger**, & C. C. Lapish (Mar 2021). A machine learning algorithm to identify bouts of drinking in rodent voluntary consumption studies. Poster presented virtually at the *Greater Indiana Society for Neuroscience Conference*.

13) G. A. Winkler, **C. Ardinger**, C. C. Lapish, N. J. Grahame (Jun 2021). Effect of ketamine on binge drinking patterns in crossed high alcohol preferring mice. Poster presented virtually at the *Research Society on Alcoholism Conference*.

14) **C. Ardinger**, C. C. Lapish, N. J. Grahame, & D. N. Linsenbardt (Jun 2020) Binge drinking ethanol is associated with changes in corticostriatal electrophysiology. Poster presented virtually at the *Research Society on Alcoholism* Conference.

15) **C. Ardinger**, C. C. Lapish & D. N. Linsenbardt (Oct 2019) Assessing the impact of excessive alcohol consumption on corticostriatal function in mice. Poster presented at the *Society for Neuroscience* Conference, Chicago, IL.

Laboratory Skills / Techniques

Stereotaxic surgery: I am skilled in aseptic technique, subject surgical preparation, anesthesia regulation, suturing, and post-operative care. Surgical procedures that I can independently and successfully execute include implantation of EEG lead, cannula, optogenetic fibers, head-fix bar, awake-behaving electrophysiology probes (fixed-wire arrays, Cambridge shanks, and neuropixels 1.0), fibers for fiber photometry recordings, GRIN lens, and targeted viral injections. I am most comfortable performing these surgeries on adult rats and mice, but I also have experience working with guinea pigs and pediatric rats.

Animal Behavior: MedPC (data collection and code), head-fixed mouse behavior, attentional set shifting, drinking-in-the-dark (including use of volumetric drinking monitor equipment to assess intake pattern), two-bottle choice, open field, Stone T-Maze, and rotarod. DeepLabCut and AnyMaze to assess activity.

Awake-behaving electrophysiology: Rig / equipment set up, design and manufacture of custom fixed-wire electrodes, data collection from multiple brain regions during anesthetized and awake-behaving neural recordings, OpenEphys software (for data collection), stereotaxic surgery (see above), and data analysis with expertise in analyzing local field potentials using techniques such as spectral decomposition (e.g. Fourier transforms, frequency filtering, wavelets) and assessment of synchrony in periodic signals (measures of coherence, phase-locking, etc.).

Other Laboratory Techniques: General animal handling, collection of retro-orbital sinus bloods, use of Analox to calculate blood ethanol concentrations, perfusions, brain extraction, euthanasia, injections (including drug preparation and dose calculations), mouse colony husbandry, mouse and rat pup weaning and sexing, cryosectioning, immunohistochemistry and basic microscopy to identify electrode / fiber and virus placement, iDISCO whole brain clearing and immunohistochemistry, light sheet microscopy.

Service / Leadership

2028	Alcohol and the Nervous System Gordon Research Seminar <i>Co-Chair</i>
Jun 2026 – Present	Animal Research and Ethics Committee: Research Society on Alcohol <i>Chair</i>
Jun 2025 – Jun 2026	Animal Research and Ethics Committee: Research Society on Alcohol <i>Co-Chair</i>
2025 – Present	Ad Hoc Journal Peer Review (Independent) <i>Alcohol: Clinical and Experimental Research (1)</i>
Dec 2024 – Feb 2026	Rutgers Postdoctoral Association <i>Co-President</i>
Dec 2020 – Jun 2025	Animal Research and Ethics Committee: Research Society on Alcohol <i>Member</i>
Aug 2021 – May 2023 <i>IUPUI</i>	Psychology Graduate Student Diversity Committee (GSDC) <i>Co-Chair</i>

Jun 2021 – May 2023 IUPUI	Graduate Out in Science, Technology, Engineering and Math (GoSTEM) <i>Secretary</i>
Aug 2021 – Aug 2022 IUPUI	Psychology Graduate Student Diversity Committee (GSDC) <i>Representative – Addiction Neuroscience</i>
May 2021 – May 2022	Supporting Truth About Animal Research (STAR) Committee <i>Research Society on Alcoholism Representative</i>
2020 – Present	Ad Hoc Journal Peer Review (with Mentorship from Advisor) <i>Journal of Neuroscience (1), Addiction Biology (2), Behavioural Processes (1).</i>

Mentoring and Community Outreach

2025 – Present	Undergraduate Honor's Thesis Mentor in the Huda Lab in Cell Biology and Neuroscience Dept. <i>Mentees: Ananya Gunda, George Xanthos, & Arnav Patel</i>
Feb 2025 New Brunswick, NJ	Aresty JSHS (Junior Science and Humanities Symposium) Judge Served as a judge at this regional science symposium for high school students
2024 – 2025	Research Society on Alcohol (RSA) Mentorship Program, Mentor
June 2022	National Research Mentoring Network (NRMN) Level 1 Training: Entering Mentoring Training
Feb 2022	Indiana Science Communication Day Participant
2019 - Present	Skype-a-Scientist, Guest Lecturer

Software Skills

Data Analysis and Presentation:

- MATLAB ([link to my Github](#))
- GraphPad Prism
- Python
- Adobe Photoshop
- SPSS
- Inkscape
- DeepLabCut

Data Collection Software:

- OpenEphys (awake-behaving ephys)
- AnyMaze
- Spike2 (EEG recording software)
- FIJI
- Nikon NIS Elements (fluorescent microscopy)
- Inspector Pro (light sheet microscopy)

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record Roles:

Fall 2018	IUPUI
Spring 2018	<i>Graduate Instructor: Research Methods Laboratory (Psychology 312)</i>
Fall 2019	<i>Mentor: Robert Stewart, PhD</i>
Fall 2017	Towson University
Spring 2018	<i>Adjunct Professor: Behavioral Statistics (Psychology 212)</i>

Teaching Assistant Roles:

Fall 2020	IUPUI
	<i>Graduate Teaching Assistant: Systems Neuroscience (Psychology 301)</i>
	<i>Mentor: Charles Goodlett, PhD</i>

- Spring 2019 **IUPUI**
Graduate Teaching Assistant: Service-Learning Capstone in Psychology (Psychology 456), Mentor: Katherine Adams, PhD
- Fall 2019 **IUPUI**
Graduate Teaching Assistant: Research Methods Lecture (Psychology 311)
Mentor: Robert Stewart, PhD
- Spring 2016 **Towson University**
Graduate Teaching Assistant: Sex Differences (Psychology 447)
Mentor: M. Paz Galupo, PhD
- Fall 2013 **Towson University**
Undergraduate Teaching Assistant: Introduction to Psychology (Psychology 101)
Mentor: Drs. David Earnest and Elizabeth Katz
- Fall 2012 **Towson University**
Undergraduate Teaching Assistant: Introduction to LGBT Studies (LGBT 101)
Mentor: Loraine Hutchins, PhD